

Optical Media

Optical media is best exemplified by DVDs. If you're rereading this, you probably also got the disks that come bundled in the package, unless of course you're just borrowing a copy from a friend (in which case, you don't know what you're missing out on – we're talking free games, wallpapers and software here). Since you can use those DVDs to get your hands on cool stuff, you already know how important they are. But there is more than what meets the eye.



Developments around optical media began in the second half of the previous century but it was only in the late 70s that any progress was made. While Sony and Philips together invented the 'audio CD', Pioneer was the company that made the most out of the 'video disc'. The complete specifications for the first generation of CDs were made in the mid 1980s by Sony and Philips and the DVD came along almost a decade later.

Optical media is called 'optical' because it's read and written using laser beams. A successful reflection from the disk is read as '1' or '0' if otherwise. Optical media boosted the growth of the software industry. It made the distribution of content (primarily audio, video and software) easy from the point of manufacturers. Back in the day, a megabyte was seen as a monstrous amount of data which no one needed to store. However, as the industry grew and software packages increased both, in quantity and size, CDs became prevalent until the dawn of new millennia when DVDs started becoming mainstream and in 2006 came the Blu-Ray format. Optical media is not only good for content distribution but also serves well as a backup and storage solution. With the beginning of this decade, it has lost appeal in favour of cloud-based alternatives such as music and app stores and is all set to die in the coming future. Nonetheless it has served mankind well.

Parachute

The term derives its meaning from the French prefix para meaning 'defense